

Q I have a Pentium 4 2.66GHz, Gigabyte 8S650GXM motherboard, 256 MB Ram, 80 GB HDD, S3 Savage 2000 64 MB card. I would like to upgrade and have already bought an Asus Pentium 4C800 DLX motherboard, 1 GB DDR 400MHz RAM, and Antec PlusView 1000 AMG cabinet. Which is the best CPU, graphic card, hard drive and sound card? Money is not an issue for me.

Raj Anand

A The Asus Pentium 4C800-DLX supports socket 478 Pentium 4 Processors with 800 MHz FSB. For maximum performance, you can opt for a P 4, 3.2 GHz processor with 1 MB cache. For the graphics, a GeForce 6800 GT card from Gainward is a good investment. Western digital drives also perform admirably; however, are harder to obtain and service might become an issue. You can safely bet on the Maxtor or Samsung SATA drives; they perform and help for them is not too far! As for the sound card, I recommend you try the on-board sound first. If you are not satisfied with the quality, then you could go in for any Creative Audigy card.

Q I want to buy a good 17" TFT monitor with fast response time (8-12 ms), analogue and digital inputs. My four-year-old CRT monitor has recently conked off, and I would like to know if this is the right time to upgrade to an LCD monitor considering the prices. Is a fall in prices expected any time soon?

M K Mech

A TFT LCD monitors are expensive and will set you back by at least 23K for a decent 17-inch model. LCD monitors with low response time of 8 to 12 ms are rare in India, and even if they are available, would be priced high. For the moment, it is not advisable to go in for an LCD monitor given the fact that they are expensive for the marginal advantages they offer.

My reasoning is also based on experience... I play lot of games and have come to the conclusion that even the worst CRT is a better bet than a reasonable LCD since they let you play without distortions. LCDs are also finicky about the resolution at which they